

STOP BEING THE BAD GUY EVERY SINGLE DAY

SCREENS DOWN, FAMILY UP

The 7-Day Reset for Better Sleep, Better Focus, and a Happier Family

7 days, not 4 weeks

Connection-focused, not clinical

Ready-to-use scripts, not theory



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FATHER OF THREE

READ THIS FIRST

YOU ARE NOT FAILING

Tonight, somewhere around dinner time, a familiar scene will play out in millions of homes.

The food is on the table. The family is together. And the room is silent — not peaceful silent, but the kind of silent where four people stare at four different screens.

If that sounds like your house, here is the first thing you need to know: **you are not failing**. You are parenting in a world engineered to steal your family's attention. The apps on your child's device were built by teams of engineers whose job is to keep them scrolling. You were never meant to win that fight with willpower alone — and neither was your child.

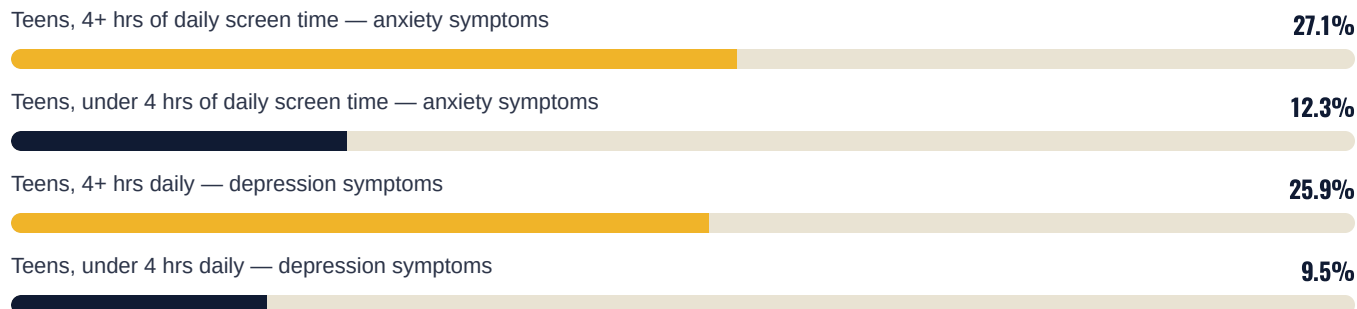
What you need is not more willpower. It's a **system**. This book gives you one: a 7-day reset that most families feel working by **Day 4** — without taking away a single device, without cold turkey, and without becoming the villain in your own home.

Seven days from now, dinner can sound different. Let's begin.

THE DATA

THE RESEARCH IS CLEAR

This isn't opinion or nostalgia for a screen-free past. Here is what the data says right now.



Source: CDC, National Health Interview Survey, 2021–2023



Source: Lurie Children's Hospital, 2025



Sources: Common Sense Media, 2025 · Australian Institute of Family Studies

12 hours a week — an entire waking Saturday — lost to screens, every single week. Every week you wait, the habits get harder to change. The good news: habits that formed fast can be reset fast, when the whole family resets together.

WHAT'S INSIDE

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INTRODUCTION

THE MOMENT AT THE GRAND CANYON

I never planned to write a parenting book. I was just a dad who noticed that dinner at our house had gone quiet.

Not the peaceful kind of quiet — the eerie silence of four people scrolling on four different devices. The breaking point came on a family vacation. We stood at the rim of the Grand Canyon, one of the most staggering sights on Earth. My kids glanced at it, snapped a photo, and went straight back to their phones.

Standing there, I realized we weren't sharing a life anymore. We were parallel scrolling through one.

What followed was months of trial and error — some of it embarrassing, most of it useful — until I found a system that worked for my real, imperfect, busy family. No extreme measures. No guilt trips. No device confiscation standoffs. Seven days, one clear step per day. That system is this book.

WHAT HAPPENS OVER THE 7 DAYS

Days 1–2

You audit your family's actual screen habits (most parents are surprised) and hold one well-prepared family meeting — exact structure, exact words.

Days 3–4

New screen-free zones and times take effect. Most families notice the first shift here: a real conversation at dinner, a kid who plays instead of asking for the tablet.

Days 5–6

You replace screen time instead of just removing it, using 50+ age-sorted activities that require zero prep.

Day 7

You lock it in — a family agreement everyone signs, plus the maintenance plan that keeps it working after the week ends.

WHAT THIS BOOK GIVES YOU

- ☐ A clear action plan for each of the 7 days — no guesswork
- ☐ Word-for-word conversation tools for the hard moments (bedtime battles, car-ride demands, "but ALL my friends have phones")
- ☐ 50+ screen-free activities sorted by age, from toddlers to teens
- ☐ Printable templates: family agreements, planners, and tracking sheets your kids actually sign
- ☐ A long-term maintenance system, including an emergency plan for when old habits creep back

ONE THING THIS BOOK NEVER ASKS YOU TO DO

Ban screens. I'm not anti-technology — I love a good Netflix night as much as anyone. This is about balance and connection, not elimination.

The average family loses 12 hours a week to screens beyond what parents themselves consider healthy. You could get that Saturday back by this time next week. Let's start.

A PREVIEW OF THE TOOLS INSIDE

A SAMPLE SCRIPT

Before we dive in, here's an example of the word-for-word tools you'll find throughout this book — for the most common objection parents hear.

THE SCENARIO

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"But ALL my friends are allowed! I'm going to be left out of everything!"

DON'T SAY

"I don't care what other families do." — This confirms their fear: you don't get it.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"You're right — a lot of your friends do have more screen time, and I get why that feels unfair. Being left out is a real worry, and I'm not ignoring it. Here's what we'll do: your time with friends is protected — we'll make sure you never miss the things that matter to you. What we're changing is the scrolling-alone time. Can you help me figure out which parts matter most to you, so we protect those first?"

Why it works: You validated the feeling, separated connection (protected) from consumption (limited), and handed them a role in the decision. Kids fight rules imposed on them. They defend rules they helped design.

Every hard conversation in this reset has a script like this one — you'll never have to improvise under pressure.

UNDERSTANDING SCREEN TIME'S IMPACT

Before you change anything, understand what you're actually dealing with — and why it matters more than you think.

1

HOW SCREENS ARE USED

Social media (TikTok, Instagram, Facebook) accounts for 2–3 hours daily; video gaming takes 1–3 hours; streaming services consume 2–4 hours; educational apps and homework add another 1–2 hours. The total frequently exceeds the waking hours available for everything else combined.

Average Daily Screen Time vs. Recommendation

AGE GROUP	AVERAGE SCREEN TIME	RECOMMENDED MAXIMUM
Toddlers (1–3 years)	2 hours	Minimal exposure
Children (4–12 years)	4–6 hours	1 hour quality content
Teens (13–18 years)	7–10 hours	2 hours recreational
Adults	11 hours	No official guideline

THE NEGATIVE IMPACT ON FAMILIES

Communication Breakdown

Families report being physically together but emotionally disconnected. The dinner table has become a silent space where each person scrolls rather than shares.

Psychological Effects

Increased anxiety and depression in adolescents, attention difficulties, sleep disruption from blue light, decreased physical activity, weakened family bonds.

Physical Health Concerns

Eye strain, poor posture leading to neck and back pain, reduced sleep quality, and the effects of a sedentary lifestyle.

The Positive Side

Video calls with distant family, educational apps with parental involvement, movie nights, creative tools. The key is *intentional use* rather than mindless consumption.

CASE STUDY

THE GARCIA FAMILY

BEFORE

Dinner together every night, but each person on their phone. Conversations limited to "pass the salt." Their teenage daughter felt lonely despite being surrounded by family.

AFTER

They implemented "Tech-Free Sundays." Within a month they felt more connected — their daughter opened up about school struggles, and family laughter returned.

SELF-ASSESSMENT: FAMILY SCREEN TIME AUDIT

Write down your answers honestly — you'll revisit them on Day 7 to measure how much has changed.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- ☐ How many hours does each family member spend on screens daily?
- ☐ How many tech-free family meals do you have per week?
- ☐ When did you last have a 30-minute conversation without device interruptions?
- ☐ What emotions arise during family screen time — isolation, connection, frustration, enjoyment?

CHAPTER TWO

PREPARING YOUR FAMILY FOR THE RESET

Jumping in without preparation leads to resistance and failure. Proper preparation means getting buy-in from everyone.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families that spend 60 minutes on a family meeting before Day 1 are dramatically more likely to complete the full 7 days.

THE FAMILY MEETING: STEP-BY-STEP

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

60-MINUTE FAMILY MEETING

0–15 min

Open Discussion

What do screens take away from our family time? What would we like to try instead?

15–30 min

Address Concerns

What are your biggest concerns about reducing screen time? How can we support each other?

30–50 min

Create the Agreement

Fill in the Family Screen Time Agreement together. Every person contributes and signs.

50–60 min

The "Last Screen Night"

Watch a favorite movie, order takeout, take a "before" photo of everyone on devices, then charge everything centrally. Creates closure and builds anticipation.

FAMILY SCREEN TIME AGREEMENT

FAMILY SCREEN TIME AGREEMENT

We, the _____ family, commit from [Start Date] to [End Date]

SCREEN-FREE ZONES

☐ Dining room during meals

☐ Bedrooms after 8 PM

☐ Living room during family time

ALWAYS ALLOWED

Educational homework · Video calls with family · Scheduled movie nights

DAILY LIMITS

Parent 1: _____ hrs Parent 2: _____ hrs
Child 1: _____ hrs Child 2: _____ hrs

REWARDS FOR SUCCESS

Weekly: _____
End of reset: _____

Signature

Signature

Signature

Date

WORKING PARENTS: HOW TO RUN THIS RESET

The daily plans in Chapters 3–6 are written as full days. If you work outside the home, don't skip the reset — re-map it. Start on a Saturday: Day 1 falls on Saturday, Day 2 on Sunday, Days 3–6 on Monday through Thursday, Day 7 on the following Saturday. Weekday template: screen-free breakfast, devices parked before school/work, the first hour home is screen-free for everyone (including your phone), then run that day's core evening activity from 6–9 PM. Move the big daytime activities — the nature outing, the backyard lunch, the family hike — to the second weekend, so they become your Day 7 celebration instead of an obstacle.

UNDERSTANDING YOUR FAMILY'S SCREEN RELATIONSHIP

" Are screens primarily used for education, entertainment, or both?

" Do screens enhance or hinder our family interactions?

" What triggers excessive screen use — boredom, stress, habit, peer pressure?

" How does each family member feel about their own screen habits?

PREPARING FOR RESISTANCE

Resistance is normal — especially from teens, and from any adult who hasn't examined their own habits. Validate feelings first, then hold firm on the agreement.

ROLE-PLAYING EXERCISE

Before Day 1, practice the hard conversations. One person plays the "resistant child," another practices responding with empathy and firmness. Rehearsing now prevents in-the-moment blowups later.

Objection Handling

OBJECTION	WHAT IT REALLY MEANS	RESPONSE STRATEGY
"I'll miss my friends online!"	Valid social concern	Let's invite friends over for game nights instead
"I'll be bored!"	Lack of alternative ideas	Let's make a list of 20 things to try together
"My friends will think I'm weird"	Peer pressure worry	This is just for one week as an experiment
"I need my phone for safety"	Genuine concern	Phones stay accessible for emergencies, just not for entertainment
"You use screens too!"	Hypocrisy concern	You're right. We're all doing this together, including parents

THE HYPOCRITE CARD

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"YOU'RE on your phone all the time!"

DON'T SAY

"I'm an adult. It's different." — Even if partly true, they hear: rules are about power, not values. That resentment resurfaces as sneaking.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"You know what? Fair. Some of mine is work — but not all of it. So catch me: if you see me scrolling during family time, you get to call 'screens down' and I park it. We're doing this as a family, not just to you."

Why it works: You modeled accountability instead of defending the indefensible, and you deputized them. A kid enforcing the family rule is a kid defending the family rule.

THE WEEKLY ACTIVITY PLANNING TEMPLATE

Before Day 1, sketch a rough plan for each of the seven days — you'll refine it as you go, but knowing tonight's activity in advance removes the single biggest source of reset failure: standing around at 6 PM with a bored family and no plan.

Weekly Schedule at a Glance

	MORNING ACTIVITY	AFTERNOON ACTIVITY	EVENING ACTIVITY	SCREEN TIME ALLOWED
Day 1	Family breakfast discussion	Set up screen-free zones	Board game night	1 hour max
Day 2	Outdoor walk	Cooking together	Story time	1 hour max
Day 3	Art project	Nature scavenger hunt	Family talent show	30 min max
Day 4	Gardening	Sports at park	Movie night (planned)	2 hours (movie only)
Day 5	Baking together	Reading time	Conversation circle	30 min max
Day 6	Family hike	Picnic lunch	Craft projects	1 hour max
Day 7	Reflection journaling	Celebration activity	Planning session	1 hour max

CREATING A SUPPORT SYSTEM

Accountability Partners

Pair up: parent with younger child, parent with teen, older sibling with younger sibling. Check in with your partner daily.

External Support

Reach out to other families attempting the same reset. Trade activity ideas and encourage each other. Sample message: "Our family is doing a 7-day screen time reset starting [date]. Want to join us or plan a tech-free playdate?"

GATHERING SUPPLIES

HAVE READY BEFORE DAY 1

- ☐ **Creative:** art supplies (paper, markers, paint, glue), craft materials (fabric, yarn, beads), cooking ingredients, science experiment kits
- ☐ **Outdoor:** sports equipment (balls, frisbees, jump ropes), magnifying glass, collection bags, picnic supplies, bikes or scooters
- ☐ **Indoor:** board and card games for a range of ages, puzzles, books, musical instruments

PRO TIP

Set up a labeled device parking station in a common area before Day 1 — one charging spot per family member, including parents.

THE "LAST SCREEN NIGHT"

The evening before your reset begins, host one special family screen night: watch a favorite movie together, order takeout so no one has to cook, and talk openly about excitement and concerns for the week ahead. Take a "before" photo of everyone on their devices — you'll want it for contrast later — then set every device to charge in its new central spot. This creates closure and builds anticipation instead of dread.

DAYS 1–2: ESTABLISHING BOUNDARIES

The first two days create the structure the rest of the week leans on — physical zones, time blocks, and the bedtime routine that anchors everything.

3

DAY 1: CREATING SCREEN-FREE ZONES

AT WORK TODAY?

This schedule assumes a full day at home — ideally Days 1–2 fall on a weekend. If you're working, keep the morning and evening blocks and move the mid-morning, lunch, and afternoon activities to your next day off.

DAY ONE

CREATING SCREEN-FREE ZONES

7–9 AM	Tech-Free Breakfast Review the family agreement. Conversation starter: "What's one thing you're excited to try this week?"
9–11 AM	Setting Up Physical Zones Walk through your home together and designate each screen-free zone as a family. Let children help create and decorate the signs. Choose a central location for the device parking station, and label each charging spot with a family member's name. Sample wording — Dining room: "Connection Zone! No phones, tablets, or screens." Bedrooms: "Rest & Recharge Zone." Living room: "Togetherness Zone."
2–4 PM	Family Cooking — Homemade Pizza Ingredients: dough, tomato sauce, cheese, assorted toppings. Assign roles: chef, sous chef, ingredient manager, taste tester. Each person builds a mini pizza (20 min), set the table together while it bakes (10 min), then eat and share "roses and thorns" (30 min).
6–8 PM	Family Game Night Tournament Quick game (20 min) → strategy game (45 min) → active game like charades (30 min).
8–8:30 PM	Evening Reflection Circle Favorite part of today? What felt challenging? What are you looking forward to tomorrow?

THE MELTDOWN (YOUNGER KIDS)

YOUR CHILD SAYS

Nothing — they're screaming, crying, maybe on the floor. The tablet just went into the parking station.

DON'T SAY

"Stop crying right now or you lose it tomorrow too." — The tears aren't defiance, they're withdrawal. Adding fear to dysregulation just teaches them the tablet is worth crying harder for.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

Kneel down, calm and quiet: "You're really upset. It's hard to stop something fun. I'm right here. When your body calms down, we'll pick what's next — blocks or bikes?"

Why it works: Co-regulation before correction. You didn't reward the meltdown with screen time, and you didn't punish the feeling. The two-option choice gives their brain somewhere to go. You became the exit ramp instead of the enemy.

Screen Time Rules by Room

ROOM	PURPOSE	RULES	VISUAL REMINDER
Dining Room	Meaningful meals	All devices in parking station during meals	Table tent card
Bedrooms	Better sleep	No screens 1 hour before bed, none overnight	Door hanger
Living Room	Family activities	Screens only for planned family movie nights	Poster on wall
Bathroom	Personal time	Quick breaks, no extended scrolling	Small sign

THE RESTAURANT WAIT

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"Can I just watch something until the food comes?"

DON'T SAY

"Fine, just keep the volume down." — The wait is precisely the boredom muscle you're rebuilding. Every surrender makes the next wait harder.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"Nope — restaurant waits are family time now. But I came prepared: would you rather play Would You Rather or twenty questions? Winner picks dessert."

Why it works: A pre-decided rule plus a prepared replacement plus tiny stakes. The wait stops being a gap to fill and becomes a ritual — and the conversation starters in the Quick Reference Guide were built for exactly this moment.

Board Games by Age

AGES 4–7	AGES 8–12	AGES 13+	ALL AGES
Candy Land, Chutes and Ladders, Go Fish, Memory	Uno, Sorry!, Pictionary, Monopoly Junior, Jenga	Codenames, Ticket to Ride, Clue, Settlers of Catan, Apples to Apples	Charades, Cards Against Humanity (family edition)

DAY 1 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Tech-free breakfast · zones established with signs · parking station created
- ☐ First screen-free family meal · evening activity completed · family reflection
- ☐ All devices charging in the central location

DAY 2: ESTABLISHING SCREEN-FREE TIMES

DAY TWO

ESTABLISHING SCREEN-FREE TIMES

9–11 AM	Nature Scavenger Hunt Checklist: 3 leaf types · a smooth stone · something red · a feather · an interesting stick · evidence of an animal · a flower or bud · something that makes noise · the smallest thing you can find · the most beautiful thing you can find. Brief phone-camera use is fine for photos.
12–1 PM	Screen-Free Lunch "If you could have any superpower for a day, what would it be?" Make it collaborative — sandwich bar, salad bar.
2–4 PM	Collaborative Family Mural Theme ideas: "Our Family's Favorite Things," "Our Dream Vacation." Choose a theme, sketch, add color, then display prominently.
6–8 PM	Family Walk and Talk First 10 min light topics, middle 20 min deeper questions, final 10 min gratitude round — three things each, including one about another family member.
8–9 PM	Screen-Free Bedtime Routine Ages 4–7: bath, 2–3 stories, cuddle and talk about the day. Ages 8–12: shower, independent reading, parent check-in. Ages 13+: hygiene, journaling or reading, optional family check-in, calm music.

Sample Daily Rhythm

TIME BLOCK	ACTIVITY	REASON
6:00–7:00 AM	Morning routine	Start day with intention
7:00–7:30 AM	Family breakfast	Connect before day begins
4:00–5:00 PM	After school/work wind-down	Transition time
6:00–7:00 PM	Dinner prep and eating	Quality family time
7:30–8:30 PM	Evening family activity	Build traditions
8:30–9:00 PM	Bedtime routine	Better sleep hygiene

THE FIVE-MORE-MINUTES LOOP

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"Just five more minutes! I need to finish this level!"

DON'T SAY

"Fine, five minutes — but that's IT." — You've just taught them the limit is soft and negotiation works. Tomorrow's opening bid will be ten.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"I get it — stopping mid-level feels like being yanked out of a movie. Finish this level, then it's screens down. And tomorrow, let's set a ten-minute warning so you can pick a good stopping point yourself."

Why it works: The frustration is real — mid-task interruption is genuinely hard, even for adults. You honored that, kept the boundary firm, and handed them the stopping control. Kids who choose their own landing spot stop fighting the landing.

Alternative Evening Activities

ACTIVITY	DURATION	MATERIALS NEEDED	BENEFITS
Stargazing	30–45 min	Blanket, star map app (brief use)	Wonder, science learning
Backyard camping	2+ hours	Tent, sleeping bags, flashlights	Adventure, bonding
Sports practice	45 min	Ball, equipment	Physical activity, teamwork
Evening picnic	1 hour	Blanket, dinner, games	Novelty, outdoor time

DAY 2 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Morning screen-free block · tech-free breakfast · outdoor scavenger hunt
- ☐ Screen-free lunch with conversation (working parents: a screen-free dinner counts)
- ☐ Creative art project · family walk · screen-free bedtime routine · evening reflection

Designate a central charging station. Everyone's device — including parents' — parks there at 8 PM. Modeling matters more than rules.

DAYS 3–4: ENGAGING ACTIVITIES

Energy and creativity. Baking, sports, a family time capsule, a talent show, gardening, and a deep dive into nature.

4

THE BOREDOM COMPLAINT (GUARANTEED ON DAYS 2–4)

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"I'm SO bored. There's NOTHING to do."

DON'T SAY

"Only boring people get bored" — or worse, scrambling to entertain them. Both teach that boredom is an emergency someone else must fix.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"Being bored feels uncomfortable — I feel it too. Your brain got used to fast entertainment, and it's re-learning how to make its own fun. It will come back, I promise. The activity jar is on the counter if you want a starting point — and if not, being bored for a while is allowed in this house."

Why it works: You named it as withdrawal, not a parenting failure. You refused the entertainment-committee job while leaving a door open. Boredom is where self-directed play starts — but only if nobody rescues them from it too fast.

DAY 3: CREATIVE AND PHYSICAL ACTIVITIES

AT WORK TODAY?

Run the morning routine before school, then jump straight to the evening block — the talent show fits weeknights well. Save the backyard lunch and outdoor projects for the weekend.

DAY THREE

CREATIVE & PHYSICAL ACTIVITIES

8–10 AM	Family Baking Project Chocolate chip cookies work for all ages: 2¼ cups flour, 1 tsp baking soda, 1 tsp salt, 1 cup butter, ¾ cup each of granulated and brown sugar, 2 eggs, 2 tsp vanilla, 2 cups chocolate chips. Assign roles: Measurer, Mixer, Shaper, Timer, Taste Tester.
10 AM–12 PM	Outdoor Sports Olympics Point system: 1st = 3, 2nd = 2, 3rd = 1, participation = 1. Crown a champion.
1–3 PM	Family Time Capsule Supplies: a shoebox or sealed container, decorating materials, paper and pens, small meaningful items. Include a family photo, letters to future selves, a newspaper, current favorites, hand tracings, predictions, and small trinkets. Decorate, write letters, gather items, seal, and choose an opening date one year out.
6–8:30 PM	Family Talent Show Prep (6–7 PM): each person prepares a 3–5 minute act. Show time (7–8 PM): host introduces each act, no criticism, only encouragement. Awards (8–8:30 PM): everyone wins a category — Most Creative, Funniest, Most Surprising, Best Effort, Hidden Talent.

Baking Recipes by Difficulty

DIFFICULTY	RECIPE	TIME	AGE APPROPRIATE
Easy	No-bake cookies	30 min	Ages 4+
Medium	Chocolate chip cookies	45 min	Ages 6+
Advanced	Decorated cupcakes	90 min	Ages 8+
Challenge	Homemade bread	3 hours	Ages 10+

Olympics Event Details

EVENT	DURATION	EQUIPMENT	SKILLS DEVELOPED
Obstacle course	20 min	Cones, ropes, boxes	Agility, problem-solving
Frisbee golf	30 min	Frisbees, targets	Aim, patience
Three-legged race	15 min	Cloth strips	Cooperation, communication
Water balloon toss	20 min	Balloons, water	Hand-eye coordination
Sack race	15 min	Pillowcases or sacks	Balance, fun

Keep a Scorecard

FAMILY MEMBER	EVENT 1	EVENT 2	EVENT 3	EVENT 4	EVENT 5	TOTAL
Parent 1						
Parent 2						
Child 1						
Child 2						

DAY 3 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Baking project · sports olympics · time capsule sealed with an opening date one year out
- ☐ Talent show performed and awards given

DAY 4: NATURE AND EXPLORATION

DAY FOUR	
NATURE & EXPLORATION	
8–11 AM	Family Gardening Project Container garden or a sunny 4×6 foot backyard plot. Roles: Garden Manager, Weed Inspector, Growth Tracker, Harvest Coordinator. Start a weekly Garden Journal.
11 AM–12 PM	Outdoor Lunch No-cook picnic or grilling with adult supervision, set up on a blanket on the grass or a folding table in the yard.
1–4 PM	Nature Adventure — Choose One Local park exploration (sketching, bird watching, tree ID); a neighborhood discovery walk (find the oldest tree, spot 5 bird species); or backyard investigation stations (insects, soil, weather, shadows).
6–8 PM	Storytelling Circle Round-robin story (30 min), personal story sharing (30 min), family history stories from parents or grandparents (30 min). Dim the lights for atmosphere.

Plant Growing Guide

PLANT	CONTAINER SIZE	DIFFICULTY	HARVEST TIME
Cherry Tomatoes	5 gallon	Easy	60–80 days
Lettuce	12" wide	Very easy	30 days
Herbs (basil, mint)	8" pot	Very easy	Ongoing
Strawberries	12" pot	Easy	60 days
Peppers	5 gallon	Medium	60–90 days

DAY 4 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Gardening project started · outdoor lunch completed (or moved to the weekend)
- ☐ Nature adventure finished · discoveries documented · storytelling circle held

CHAPTER FIVE

DAYS 5–6: DEEPENING CONNECTIONS

Active listening, cultural cooking, community service, and a vulnerability circle.

These two days change how your family communicates.

DAY 5: COMMUNICATION AND SHARED EXPERIENCES

AT WORK TODAY?

These connection activities need unhurried time. On weekdays, use the evening block — cooking together works perfectly on a weeknight — and move the family hike to the second weekend as your reset finale.

ACTIVE LISTENING — THE CORE SKILL

Each person takes 5 minutes to share while others practice: eye contact, no interrupting, one follow-up question, summarize what you heard.

Communication Exercises

EXERCISE	HOW IT WORKS
Mirror Talk	Practice rephrasing skills with a partner. One person speaks, the other rephrases before responding.
Emotion Charades	Recognize feelings by acting them out without words. Others guess the emotion being portrayed.
Compliment Circle	Build positivity by giving specific compliments. Each person compliments the person on their left.
Question Game	Engage in deep conversations by asking thoughtful questions. Avoid surface-level questions.

DAY FIVE

COMMUNICATION & SHARED EXPERIENCES

8–10 AM	Active Listening Breakfast Each person shares something they're worried about, excited about, or wish others knew — while others practice active listening.
10 AM–1 PM	Cultural Cooking Experience Choose a country, research it (20 min), gather ingredients (30 min), cook together (45–90 min), eat with a cultural theme (30 min).
1–3 PM	Family Service Project At-home: cards for nursing home residents, cookies for neighbors. Out in the community: park clean-up, food bank volunteering. Define the goal, assign tasks, set a timeline.
6–8 PM	Vulnerability Sharing Circle Ground rules: what's shared stays here, no fixing unless asked, equal time, okay to pass. Prompts by depth — comfortable, deeper, vulnerable.

Cooking Around the World

COUNTRY	DISH	DIFFICULTY	PREP TIME
Italy	Spaghetti Carbonara	Easy	30 min
Mexico	Tacos al Pastor	Medium	45 min
Japan	Teriyaki Chicken	Easy	40 min
India	Chicken Tikka Masala	Medium	60 min
Greece	Greek Salad & Pita	Easy	25 min
France	Ratatouille	Medium	75 min

Sharing Prompts by Depth

LEVEL 1 — COMFORTABLE

What's your favorite memory from this week? · What's something that made you laugh recently? · What are you looking forward to?

LEVEL 2 — DEEPER

What's something that's been bothering you lately? · When did you feel misunderstood this week? · What's a mistake you made that you learned from?

LEVEL 3 — VULNERABLE

What's a fear you have that you don't talk about? · When do you feel most alone? · What's something you wish was different about our family?

GRATITUDE JAR

Before bed: each person writes 3 things they're grateful for, including one about another family member. Save the jar to reread in a month.

DAY 6: SHARED ADVENTURES AND QUALITY TIME

DAY SIX SHARED ADVENTURES & QUALITY TIME	
7–11 AM	Extended Family Hike Before you go: trail suited to the least fit member, water, snacks, sunscreen, first-aid kit, charged phone. Every 15 min rotate: Nature Bingo, Story Stones, Gratitude Rounds, Would You Rather, Silent Walking.
11 AM–1 PM	Trail Lunch or Picnic Sandwiches, a custom trail-mix bar, or fresh options. Conversation starter: "If you could bring one person from history on this hike, who would it be?"
2–4 PM	Collaborative Project — Choose One Build a fort or treehouse; create a family recipe book; or film a family documentary interviewing each member.
6–9 PM	Special Dinner and Reflection Appetizer talk (Rose, Thorn, Bud), main course discussion, dessert dialogue, then build a Reset Week Scrapbook page together.

Which Trail Difficulty Is Right for Us?

EASY	MODERATE	CHALLENGING
1–2 miles, 1–2 hours. All ages. Bring water and snacks.	2–4 miles, 2–3 hours. Ages 6+. Water, lunch, first aid.	4+ miles, 3–4 hours. Ages 10+. Full pack, map, extra supplies.

Theme Party Nights

THEME	MENU · DECORATION · ACTIVITY
Italian Night	Spaghetti, salad, garlic bread · Red checkered tablecloth · Learn Italian phrases
Breakfast for Dinner	Pancakes, bacon, eggs · Morning-themed · Everyone wears pajamas
Taco Bar	Build-your-own tacos · Colorful napkins · Salsa music
Backyard BBQ	Burgers, corn, coleslaw · Picnic style · Eat outside

DAYS 5–6 CHECKLIST

- ☐ Active listening practiced · cultural cooking · service project · vulnerability circle held
- ☐ Family hike · collaborative project · special dinner · scrapbook page created

DAY 7: REFLECTION AND PLANNING

Measure how far you've come, celebrate every win, and decide what your family looks like from here.

6

INDIVIDUAL JOURNALING

Give each family member 30 minutes of quiet time to reflect before you come back together.

7-DAY RESET REFLECTION	
DAILY HIGHLIGHTS Day 1: Day 2: Day 3: Day 4: Day 5: Day 6: Day 7: 	BIGGEST CHALLENGE HOW I OVERCAME IT
MOST MEANINGFUL MOMENT WHY IT MATTERED 	WHAT I WANT TO CONTINUE WHAT I'LL REMEMBER MOST

Looking Back

Most enjoyable activity? The hardest moment? How did relationships change?

Screen Awareness

How much did you think about screens? What did you use that time for instead?

Personal Growth

What new skill did you discover? What are you most proud of?

Looking Forward

What do you want to continue? What commitment are you making?

STRUCTURED FAMILY MEETING

Come together for a family meeting (10 AM–12 PM works well) to compare notes and measure the week.

Meeting Agenda (10 AM–12 PM)

TIME	TOPIC	FORMAT
10:00–10:15	Share individual reflections	Each person shares 2 min
10:15–10:30	Assess screen time changes	Review data together
10:30–10:45	Celebrate successes	Recognition and praise
10:45–11:00	Acknowledge challenges	Open discussion
11:00–11:30	Plan for future	Create sustainable plan
11:30–12:00	Create new agreement	Sign and commit

BEFORE / AFTER

FAMILY SCREEN TIME ANALYSIS

BEFORE THE RESET

Daily hours per person, tech-free meals per week, quality of interaction — from your Chapter 1 audit.

AFTER THE RESET

Same measures, one week later, plus time gained for connection.

Screen Time Comparison Chart

	BEFORE RESET	DURING RESET	DIFFERENCE
Parent 1	___ hrs	___ hrs	___ hrs
Parent 2	___ hrs	___ hrs	___ hrs
Child 1	___ hrs	___ hrs	___ hrs
Child 2	___ hrs	___ hrs	___ hrs
Family Total	___ hrs	___ hrs	___ hrs

Quality of Interaction — Before and After

	BEFORE	AFTER CHANGE
Conversation quality		
Conflict level		
Feeling heard		
Feeling connected		
Overall family satisfaction		

RECOGNITION ACTIVITY

Each person gives one specific appreciation to another: "I noticed when you..." · "I appreciated when you..." · "Thank you for..."

CELEBRATING WINS

ACHIEVEMENT CHECKLIST

- ☐ 7 screen-free dinners completed
- ☐ Tried 5+ new activities as a family
- ☐ Had meaningful daily conversations
- ☐ Discovered new family interests
- ☐ Laughed more, argued less
- ☐ Felt more connected as a family

ACKNOWLEDGING CHALLENGES

For each challenge that came up this week — boredom without screens, sibling conflicts, work or school needs, missing friends online, weather limits, parent stress — discuss: What made this difficult? How did we try to address it? How can we prepare for this next time?

Common Challenges Chart

CHALLENGE	HOW OFTEN	TRIGGER	SOLUTION ATTEMPTED	FUTURE STRATEGY
Boredom without screens				
Sibling conflicts				
Work/school needs				
Missing friends online				
Weather limits				
Parent stress				

CREATING SUSTAINABLE PRACTICES

ONGOING FAMILY SCREEN TIME PLAN

Complete this on Day 7 and post it alongside your original agreement.

DAILY SCREEN-FREE TIMES

Morning:

Evening:

All meals stay screen-free ✓

WEEKLY TRADITIONS WE'RE KEEPING

FAMILY CODE WORD

Anyone can say this to call an emergency family meeting.

WEEKLY SCREEN-FREE BLOCKS

Mon:

Wed:

Fri:

Weekend:

PERMANENT TECH-FREE ZONES

Dining room/kitchen · bedrooms · bathroom · car (except navigation)

SPECIAL CIRCUMSTANCES

Family movie night: Fri 7–9 PM · documentaries: weekends · video calls with relatives: anytime · emergencies: always allowed

MONTHLY ACTIVITY POOL

Outdoor:

Creative:

Learning:

Service:

Signature

Signature

Signature

Date

MONTHLY CHECK-IN

First Sunday of each month: Review (10 min) — what worked, what didn't; Adjust (10 min) — do limits or zones need changing; Plan (10 min) — choose activities from the pool.

Monthly Tracking Template

MONTH	SCREEN TIME GOAL MET?	BEST FAMILY ACTIVITY	CHALLENGE FACED	ADJUSTMENT MADE
Month 1				
Month 2				
Month 3				

EMERGENCY PLAN & ACCOUNTABILITY

Set Up Accountability Systems

Daily Check-In

5 minutes before dinner. Each person shares: "Did I follow screen limits today?" No judgment, just awareness – problem-solve together if anyone struggled.

Weekly Family Tech Review

Every Sunday evening, 15 minutes. Review screen-time stats if you're using a tracking app. Celebrate successes, adjust as needed.

Buddy System

Pair family members. Buddies check in with each other daily, support each other, and celebrate each other's wins.

IF OLD SCREEN HABITS RETURN

WARNING SIGNS

24-HOUR RESET PLAN

Devices to parking station · schedule an activity within 24 hrs
· family meeting · recommit to the agreement

FAMILY CODE WORD

SYSTEMS

Daily check-in (5 min before dinner) · weekly Sunday tech review · buddy system pairs

THE RELAPSE (TWO WEEKS LATER)

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"We don't do the no-screens thing anymore, right?" — and they're not wrong. Dinner was silent again tonight.

DON'T SAY

"That's it — we're doing the whole week over again." — Threat framing turns the reset into a punishment, something done TO them again instead of something you built together.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"You're right, we drifted — me included. That's normal; it's even in the book. We're not redoing the week. We're doing a 24-hour mini-reset starting after dinner: phones in the station, one activity from the jar, and tomorrow we look at the agreement together and fix what stopped working."

Why it works: It names the drift without blame, invokes the mechanism everyone already agreed to — the emergency plan above — and scales the response to 24 hours, not 7 days. Relapse becomes family debugging, not family failure.

SCREEN TIME RESET CHAMPION

This certifies that

successfully completed the 7-Day Screen Time Reset, with the achievement of

Date

Signed

CELEBRATION AND CLOSING RITUAL

- ☐ Special outing or home celebration — favorite dinner, cake, dance party
- ☐ Awards ceremony: Best Team Player, Most Creative, Strongest Screen Resistance
- ☐ Add reflection letters and photos to the Day 3 time capsule
- ☐ Closing ritual: group hug, plant a tree, light a candle, or sign and frame the agreement

LONG-TERM SUCCESS STRATEGIES

The reset is just the beginning. Here's how to make the changes permanent.

THE FIRST 30 DAYS AFTER RESET

Momentum fades unless you keep tending it. Here's the maintenance rhythm that keeps a 7-day reset from becoming a 7-day memory.

Weeks 1–2

Expect regression — normal. Review the agreement daily, keep zones strict, maintain 3+ screen-free dinners.

Weeks 3–4

Evaluate what's working. Adjust limits if needed, but don't abandon them. Add one new tradition.

90-Day Milestone Plan

	DAY 30	DAY 60	DAY 90
Action	First monthly review meeting	Open time capsule	Full family assessment
Evaluation	Assess progress, adjust plan	Compare predictions to reality	Measure long-term changes

CREATING FAMILY TRADITIONS

Weekly — Tech-Free Tuesday

One guaranteed screen-free dinner with a rotating conversation theme.

Weekly — Sunday Morning Adventure

No screens until noon, an outdoor activity, and a special breakfast.

Weekly — Friday Family Fun Night

A rotating activity chooser with homemade treats.

Monthly Rhythm

First Friday: family meeting. Third Saturday: an all-day adventure. Last Sunday: a service day.

AGE-SPECIFIC STRATEGIES

Toddlers (1–3)

Minimal exposure except video calls. Never use screens as a pacifier. Sensory play, reading, music.

Young Children (4–7)

Max 1 hour of quality content daily, co-viewing when possible. Imaginative play, building, art.

Tweens (8–12)

1–2 hours recreational after homework. Earn time through responsibilities.

Teens (13–18)

2–3 hours recreational, more autonomy with accountability. Focus on the relationship over the rules.

"I HATE THIS FAMILY"

YOUR TEEN SAYS

"This is SO unfair. Everything fun is banned. I hate it here."

DON'T SAY

"After everything we do for you—" — Now the conversation is about your hurt feelings and their tone, and the actual issue is gone.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"You're allowed to hate the rule. You don't have to like it for it to matter. Honestly, I'd rather hear 'this sucks' than have you pretend. When you've cooled off, tell me which part feels most unfair — and at the weekly review, if something needs adjusting, we'll adjust it together."

Why it works: Permission to feel is not permission to break the rule — kids can hold both. And you routed the protest into the system (the weekly review) instead of the moment, which is exactly where you want appeals filed.

LEFT OUT OF THE GROUP CHAT

YOUR TEEN SAYS

"Everyone's seen it. All the memes are about it. I literally can't be part of any conversation."

DON'T SAY

"If your friendships depend on a TV show, they aren't real friendships." — That dismisses the actual architecture of teen social life. They won't argue; they'll just stop telling you.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"Okay — that's a real thing, not a silly thing. Shared shows are how your group talks. So let's make it work on purpose: pick the show, we'll schedule it, and it stays out of the scrolling-alone pile. Watching what your friends watch is connection. Three hours of clips about the show is consumption. We protect the first."

Why it works: It applies the book's core distinction — connection versus consumption — to the case teens care most about, and converts passive scrolling into planned, legitimate viewing they don't have to sneak.

HANDLING DIFFICULT SCENARIOS

COMMON SCENARIOS AND RESPONSES

- ☐ **Homework needs a screen:** supervised station, timer, no multitasking, hard stop.
- ☐ **Bad weather:** fort building, indoor scavenger hunt, cooking project, board game marathon.
- ☐ **A parent travels:** scheduled video call as the one exception.
- ☐ **Kids visit friends:** talk to other parents, send a non-screen activity idea.
- ☐ **Holidays/vacations:** relax some limits but keep screen-free meals and bedtime rules.
- ☐ **Facing resistance:** acknowledge feelings, remind of the agreement, offer a choice within limits.

"BUT IT'S FOR HOMEWORK"

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"I NEED my laptop — it's for homework." (From behind a screen that is definitely playing videos.)

DON'T SAY

"Let me see it right now. I knew you were lying." — A surveillance opener turns study time into a cat-and-mouse game you will lose.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"Homework screens are always allowed — that was never in question. Let's make it easy on both of us: homework happens at the kitchen table with the door open, and when it's done, the laptop goes back to the station. That way I never have to hover, and you never have to prove anything."

Why it works: Legitimate use stays protected without interrogation. The environment — an open, supervised workspace — replaces policing, which is exactly what the scenario list above prescribes: supervised station, timer, no multitasking.

THE MIDNIGHT DISCOVERY

THE SCENARIO

You find the tablet under their pillow at 11 PM.

DON'T SAY

"You LIED to me? No screens for a month!" — Escalation doesn't teach better habits. It teaches better hiding.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

Next morning, calm: "I found your tablet in your bed. I'm not going to yell. I want to understand what made it worth breaking our agreement — a group chat? A game? Trouble falling asleep? ... The consequence we all signed is still happening. But let's also fix the real problem, so the rule gets easier to keep."

Why it works: You separated the child from the act, kept the consequence predictable instead of rage-sized, and treated the sneaking as data. If it's FOMO, protect connection time. If it's sleep, solve sleep. The rule survives and the reason it broke gets addressed.

THE GRANDMA LOOPHOLE

YOUR CHILD SAYS

"But Grandma lets us watch ALL day."

DON'T SAY

"Well, Grandma's wrong." — You've undermined an ally and taught them that adults can be played against each other.

SAY THIS INSTEAD

"Grandma's house has Grandma magic — some things are special there that aren't everyday things. Our house runs on our plan, the one you signed. And I'll talk with Grandma myself, so her house stays special without undoing our week."

Why it works: Rules that are domain-specific and stable — her house, her magic; our house, our plan — are easier for kids to accept than rules that claim to follow them everywhere. And the adult conversation happens adult-to-adult, off-stage.

TOOLS AND RESOURCES

Physical Tools

Device parking station with individual labeled spots · a timer for screen-time blocks · an activity cabinet.

Family Activity Binder

Activity pool list, favorite recipes, conversation-starter cards, game rules, local attraction ideas.

Apps for Monitoring (Not Controlling)

APP	PURPOSE	BEST FOR	COST
Screen Time (iOS)	Track usage	iPhones/iPads	Free
Digital Wellbeing (Android)	Monitor habits	Android devices	Free
Moment	Family awareness	All devices	Free/Premium
OurPact	Family management	Families with young kids	Subscription
Forest	Focus building	Teens and adults	\$2

MEASURING SUCCESS

WEEKLY TRACKING SHEET

Mon–Sun daily screen-time hours vs. goal · screen-free meals: ____ / 21 · family activities: ____ (goal 3+)

SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

More spontaneous conversation · increased laughter · fewer arguments about screens · better sleep · stronger family relationships.

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

If a child shows extreme anger when devices are removed, sneaks devices, or shows declining grades — consider a family therapist, pediatrician, or school counselor. Getting help is a strength, not a failure.

Where to Find Help

Professional Support

Family therapist · child psychologist · school counselor
· pediatrician.

Support Groups

Online communities for parents setting screen limits ·
local parenting groups · school parent organizations.

Educational Resources

Common Sense Media · Center for Humane Technology
· American Academy of Pediatrics guidelines
· ScreenStrong.

THE LONG VIEW

MONTHLY AFFIRMATIONS — POST THESE WHERE THE FAMILY CAN SEE

"We choose connection over screens" · "Quality time is our priority" · "We support each other's growth" · "Balance brings us joy" · "Our family is worth the effort"

6-MONTH CHECK-IN — QUESTIONS TO ANSWER

- ☐ How has our family changed?
- ☐ What habits have become automatic?
- ☐ What still requires effort?
- ☐ What unexpected benefits emerged?
- ☐ Where do we want to go from here?

1-YEAR VISION

One year from now, our family will...

SCREEN TIME

ACTIVITIES

COMMUNICATION

TRADITIONS

CONNECTION

WE COMMIT TO THIS VISION.

Everyone signs below.

Signature

Signature

Signature

Date

QUICK REFERENCE GUIDE

Dog-ear this section. When something goes sideways, the answer is probably here.

Emergency Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	SOLUTION
Kids bored without screens	Pull an activity from the pre-made list, go outside immediately
Parent too tired to enforce	Call a family meeting, ask for everyone's help
Regression after success	Don't abandon the plan — do a 24-hour mini-reset
Conflict about rules	Return to the family agreement, renegotiate if needed
Special circumstance	Allow the exception but return to normal the next day
Feeling overwhelmed	Pick ONE screen-free time to maintain, rebuild from there

Screen-Free Activity Quick List

15-Minute Activities

Card game · walk around the block · dance party · quick craft · read a chapter aloud.

30-Minute Activities

Board game · bake cookies · backyard play · art project · bike ride.

1-Hour+ Activities

Hiking · museum visit · cooking a meal together · movie night (occasional) · big project work.

Conversation Starters by Situation

In the Car

"If you could have dinner with anyone, who and why?" ·
"What's the funniest thing that happened today?" · "If you won the lottery, what's the first thing you'd do?"

At Dinner

"What's something that surprised you today?" · "Tell me about someone who was kind today" · "What's something you're looking forward to?"

Before Bed

"What are you grateful for from today?" · "What was challenging today?" · "What do you need from me tomorrow?"

FAMILY SCREEN TIME SUPPORT NETWORK

Fill this in during Week 1 — you'll want it before you need it.

FAMILY ACCOUNTABILITY PARTNER

Name: _____ Phone: _____

PARTICIPATING FRIEND FAMILIES

PROFESSIONAL RESOURCES (IF NEEDED)

Therapist:

Pediatrician:

School counselor:

EMERGENCY CONTACT (DEVICE-FREE OUTINGS)

Name:

Phone:

FINAL ENCOURAGEMENT

Your family has incredible potential for connection, growth, and joy. The changes you make today create the family culture of tomorrow.

Screens aren't the enemy. Mindless consumption is. Progress over perfection. Your family is worth it.

LAWRENCE MARTIN

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